

Image 1.1: Map of the Silk Route
Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

Kashmir's famous epic, *Rajatarangini*, written in 1148 AD by Kalhana, records that Rozabal is the grave of a king. The epic also reveals that Ashoka brought Buddhism to Kashmir in the mid-3rd century BC,[4] where it took root and spread to Tibet, China and Central Asia.

It was only during the reign of the Sultan dynasty from 1339 that Islam overpowered Hinduism and Buddhism in the region. Sikandar Butshikan, the iconoclastic sixth sultan of the Shah Miri dynasty, who ruled from 1389 to 1413, had attempted to 'sanitise' the valley of all its non-Muslim inhabitants and their culture. This was the period when Kashmir's patron saint Nund Rishi, realising that there was no other option, converted to Islam and came to be called Sheikh Nur-ud-Din Wali or the 'Light of the Faith'. Nund Rishi preached and practised a faith of tolerance and inclusivity called 'Kashmiriyat'.[5] This involved respecting all religious